several Modi rallies.[12] By 2012, his third election as a sitting chief minister, this outreach had been further fine-tuned.

The journalist Nistula Hebbar too described Modi as 'India's unlikeliest sex symbol'. His political projection was, in her view, that of an 'alpha male who set things right', who was not 'afraid to speak out his mind' and combined this personality projection with a focus on developmental issues around women.[13] 'Modi, according to those in the know, has always been more than conscious of the female vote,' she wrote. 'Apart from a helping hand to women to run small-scale businesses and expressing concern about their general safety in public spaces, he made a conscious effort to reach out to women voters. During the 2012 Assembly polls in Gujarat, he deployed Nirmala Sitharaman, Meenakshi Lekhi and Smriti Irani to especially target women voters in rural areas. His rallies have consistently attracted a more female audience than male in Gujarat. The general atmosphere of a rise of crime against women, especially following the December 16 gang rape in Delhi [the Nirbhaya case] and the Central government's complete misreading of the popular mood, has allowed Modi's muscular image to gain traction among women.'[14]

This gender-focused image was an important but underrated building block of Modi's prime-ministerial bid in 2014. If women felt unsafe, then 'we have no right to call ourselves "mard" [man]', he declared at a 2013 rally in Chhotaudepur. Talking of attacks on women in the land of 'Sita and Savitris', the prime ministerial-candidate declared that 'some men with pervert brains blame women for such acts', further asserting that such assaults were 'no fault of the woman' and that the 'fault lies in the pervert minds of men'.[15] Similarly, Modi denounced female infanticide at a FICCI meeting that year, saying that India had 'regressed back to the 18th century' with such practices. Arguing that 'we, particularly men, underestimate the power of women', he said 'women are two steps ahead of men' and a 'modern India' could only be built by 'taking pride in our women and their powers'.[16]

This image of being a 'mard' is what Modi subliminally tapped into in 2014. As the sociologist Sanjay Srivastava argued, his first national campaign and the appeal of his pre-prime ministerial